

a favourite with Cher and the Sex Pistols—has delighted desi trendsetters like Ness Wadia and Natasha Poonawala. Priya Kishore, who stocks them at her Mumbai store Bombay Electric, along with accessories from cult Japanese brand Comme des Garçons, sunglasses from Blinde and footwear from United Nude, has seen the subtle shift in perception first hand. "Today, most Indians are well-travelled and fashionably astute. Our notion of luxury has metamorphosed from being a display of wealth to something that you can enjoy and which fits your personality. Luxury doesn't always have to be expensive," she says. And that's where boutique brands come into the picture. "You can't underestimate the Indian buyer. There are a lot of shoppers who are connoisseurs and have specialised tastes. And boutique brands are not just about fashion but they are a lifestyle statement," says Kishore.

Fashion designer Nachiket Barve also believes clothes are fast becoming an expression of the self rather than value. "There is a distinct need to conform yet stand out. The idea is to push your style meter up by a decibel. With a growing fashion consciousness, how you dress is fast becoming a statement about who you are and how you live," he says. People are interpreting clothes in their own unique way. And these niche brands promise exclusivity that is not in-your-face.

In a luxury fixated and saturated world comes this counter-trend where sartorial statements are becoming unique and people are tailoring their looks and lives to suit themselves—where a pair of Victoria Beckham jeans meets a Hussein Chalayan top and Diane von Fürstenberg shares rack space with Sienna Miller's label Twenty8Twelve. Bandyng these names around is Tarini Jindal of Mumbai-based store Muse, who also stocks boutique labels like Anna Sui, Arabella Ramsay, Nicola Finetti and Vanessa Bruno. "India is hot right now. And the response from brands and buyers has been phenomenal," says Jindal. On the verge of introducing Indian shoppers to Zac Posen and Matthew Williamson come spring-summer, Jindal says the boutique brands themselves have shown great excitement at the prospect of retailing in India. "We put in a lot of research to determine what brands were suitable for the Indian market. Last season we had introduced a few Australian brands and now we are going to look at the Brazilian market and the Japanese

This Los Angeles-based label retails a stylish and sleek line of ensembles in luxurious fabrics. Dresses, tailored skirts and trousers meet detailed tops and blouses.

Detailed pinstripe and pleated cotton dress from actor Sienna Miller's label. Also on offer are chic shirts, trousers and skirts in crisp fabrics.



designers next year," says Jindal, who is taking her motley group of labels to Delhi via trunk shows and is currently in talks with Elizabeth Hurley to bring her swimwear label to desi shores.

While the fashion market gets flooded with niche international labels, shoppers like Mitali Gandhi are only too happy to have access to brands like Petra from Russia and Hanni Y from Korea, available at Muse. "I'd rather buy something unique rather than compete with the monogrammed counterfeit that my colleague picked up in Bangkok," says the management consultant. Even as luxury moves from the obviously ostentatious to the discreetly distinct, boutique labels are likely to find more and more takers in India. "When you sport a niche label you are not only guaranteed that no one else will own a similar creation but you also send out the message that you are putting a great deal of thought into what you are wearing," says Barve. And with fashion gradually veering towards the individualistic path, this tribe of sharp dressers is bound to thrive. It's time to dress yourself apart from the crowd.

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